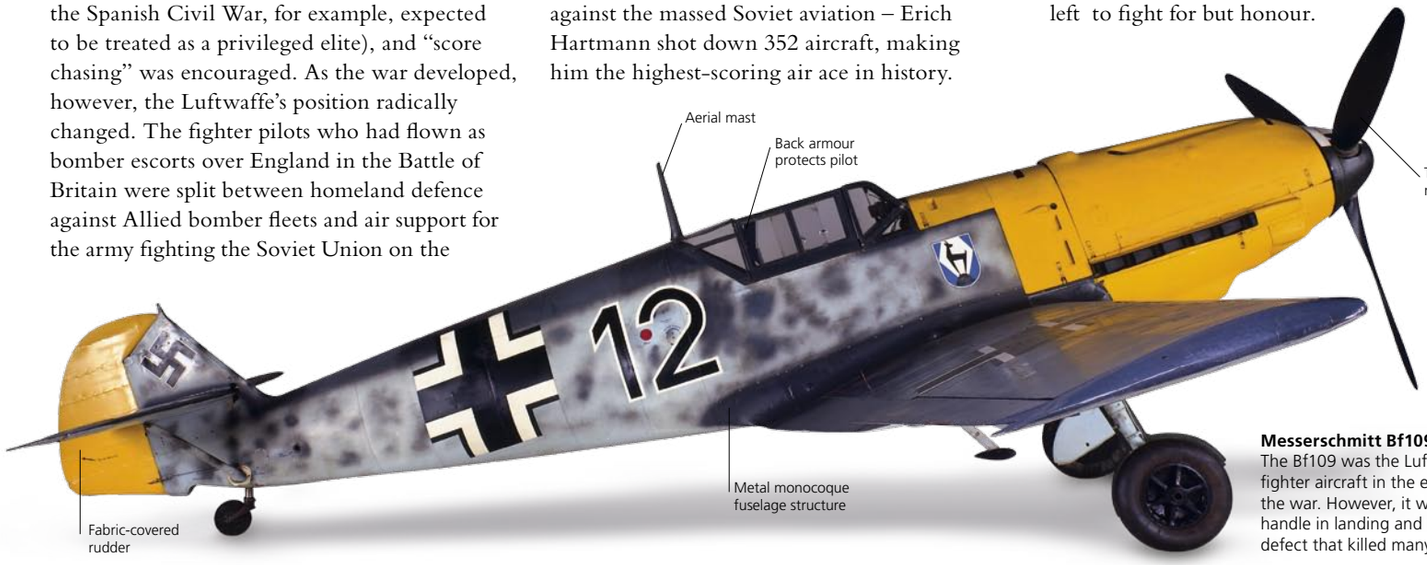
GERMAN FIGHTER PILOTS

In the early years of World War II, German fighter pilots were superior to their opponents in training, tactics, and combat experience. The Luftwaffe operated as a meritocracy with an anti-authoritarian ethos. Status was based on flying experience and combat record (those who had served in the Condor Legion during the Spanish Civil War, for example, expected to be treated as a privileged elite), and "score chasing" was encouraged. As the war developed, however, the Luftwaffe's position radically changed. The fighter pilots who had flown as bomber escorts over England in the Battle of Britain were split between homeland defence against Allied bomber fleets and air support for the army fighting the Soviet Union on the Eastern Front. Although the home defence units performed magnificently in both day and night fighting, they were subject to steady attrition that turned into massive losses once the US long-range fighter escorts appeared over Germany. On the Eastern Front losses were even heavier, although German pilots ran up vast kill-tallies against the massed Soviet aviation – Erich Hartmann shot down 352 aircraft, making him the highest-scoring air ace in history.

By the winter of 1944 the Luftwaffe was short of fuel and of experienced pilots. Many of the surviving fighter aces, such as Adolf Galland, ended up flying experimental Messerschmitt Me 262 jets as interceptors in a last-ditch air defence of Germany against overwhelming Allied numbers. By then there was nothing left to fight for but honour.



Messerschmitt Bf109D
The Bf109 was the Luftwaffe's key fighter aircraft in the early years of the war. However, it was tricky to handle in landing and take-off, a defect that killed many pilots.

JAPANESE NAVAL PILOTS

The Japanese pilots who caused devastation at the US naval base at Pearl Harbor, Hawaii, in December 1941, were part of the finest naval air force in the world. Not only were their aircraft, such as the Mitsubishi Reisen "Zero" fighter, of the highest quality, but the pilots themselves were superbly trained and battle-hardened, having fought in Japan's war against China since 1937.

Japanese naval aviators continued to hold their own against the US in the Pacific War in 1942 and 1943, but the number of experienced pilots fell sharply through battle casualties, while the performance of US pilots and their aircraft steadily improved. In the battle of the Philippine Sea in June 1944, the Japanese lost 300 aircraft in a single day and the entire Japanese carrier fleet was destroyed, leaving naval aviators to operate from shore. During the battle of Leyte Gulf in October 1944, the First Air Fleet, based on the Philippines, initiated suicide tactics. Kamikaze ("Divine Wind") pilots, as the Americans called them, packed their aircraft with explosives and tried to crash on the decks of US warships. They donned a *hachimaki* headband once worn by the samurai, a sign of their supposed status as elite warriors. But since the lives of experienced pilots were precious, the kamikaze role soon in practice devolved to barely trained youngsters. By April 1945, a mass "special attack" force of over 2,000 aircraft dedicated to suicide attacks had been formed. In total, kamikaze raids sank 34 warships and damaged 288 by the war's end.



Kamikaze attack
A Japanese Zero fighter crashes onto the deck of the USS *Missouri* during the wave of suicide attacks launched against the Allied fleet in 1944–45.

"MAY OUR DEATH BE AS SUDDEN AND CLEAN AS THE SHATTERING OF CRYSTAL."

KAMIKAZE PILOT WRITING BEFORE HIS MISSION